

Changing My Patterns:

Short-Term & Long-Term Goals Worksheet

A guide to identifying problematic behaviors and building goals for change

Name: _____ Date: _____

Section 1: Understanding Your Patterns

Many people experience unwanted, repetitive thoughts that feel intrusive and distressing. These thoughts often trigger strong urges to perform certain actions or rituals to reduce the distress or prevent something bad from happening. Over time, these patterns can take up hours of your day, interfere with relationships, work, and the things that matter most to you.

This worksheet will help you:

- Identify the specific behaviors and patterns that are causing problems in your life
- Understand how these patterns steal your time and energy
- Set clear, achievable short-term goals (1-4 weeks) to begin changing these behaviors
- Set meaningful long-term goals (3-12 months) for the life you want to build
- Create a step-by-step plan to move from where you are to where you want to be

Important: The goal is NOT to eliminate all uncomfortable thoughts or feelings. The goal IS to reduce the behaviors that keep you stuck, so you can live more freely.

Section 2: Identifying My Problematic Behaviors

Below is a list of common patterns that can become problematic. Check ALL that apply to you, and for each one you check, rate how much time it takes from your day and how much distress it causes (1 = mild, 5 = severe).

A. Checking Behaviors

Repeating actions to make sure something is 'right' or to prevent harm

- ☐ Checking locks, stove, appliances, or switches repeatedly
- ☐ Re-reading emails, texts, or documents multiple times before sending
- ☐ Checking that I haven't accidentally hurt someone
- ☐ Going back to verify I completed a task (even when I know I did)
- ☐ Checking my body for signs of illness or disease
- ☐ Asking others repeatedly if something is okay or if I did something wrong

B. Washing / Cleaning Behaviors

Excessive cleaning or washing driven by fears of contamination or disgust

- ☐ Washing hands repeatedly or for extended periods
- ☐

Avoiding touching objects, surfaces, or people due to contamination fears

- ☐ Excessive cleaning of household items, clothes, or personal belongings
- ☐ Showering or bathing for extended periods or with rigid routines
- ☐ Using hand sanitizer excessively throughout the day

C. Repeating / Ordering / Symmetry Behaviors

Needing things to feel 'just right,' even, or perfectly arranged

- ☐ Arranging objects until they feel perfectly symmetrical or 'right'
- ☐ Repeating actions a certain number of times (e.g., flicking a switch 4 times)
- ☐ Re-doing tasks (writing, walking through doors, sitting down) until it feels right
- ☐ Counting, tapping, or touching things in patterns
- ☐ Getting stuck on a task because it doesn't feel 'complete'

D. Mental Rituals / Thinking Patterns

Internal actions done in your mind to neutralize distressing thoughts

- ☐ Mentally reviewing events over and over to make sure nothing bad happened
- ☐ Praying, counting, or repeating phrases silently to 'undo' a bad thought
- ☐ Trying to replace a 'bad' thought with a 'good' one
- ☐ Analyzing and questioning your own thoughts endlessly (Am I a bad person?)
- ☐ Seeking mental certainty - needing to 'figure out' if a thought means something

E. Avoidance Behaviors

Avoiding places, people, situations, or objects to prevent distress

- ☐ Avoiding certain places because they trigger uncomfortable thoughts
- ☐ Avoiding specific people, news, TV shows, or movies
- ☐ Not doing activities I used to enjoy because of fear or discomfort
- ☐ Avoiding making decisions (fear of making the 'wrong' choice)
- ☐ Delegating tasks to others so I don't have to face the discomfort
- ☐ Avoiding being alone with certain people (children, partner) due to intrusive thoughts

F. Reassurance-Seeking Behaviors

Repeatedly asking others or searching for information to feel certain

- ☐ Asking family/friends 'Are you sure?' or 'Is this okay?' repeatedly
- ☐ Searching the internet for hours to confirm or deny a fear
- ☐ Confessing thoughts to others to get reassurance that you are not a bad person
- ☐ Needing others to tell you that nothing bad will happen
- ☐ Comparing yourself to others to check if your thoughts are 'normal'

Section 3: How These Patterns Affect My Life

For your TOP 3 most problematic behaviors (from Section 2), describe how they impact your daily life. Be specific - this helps you see exactly what you are working to change.

Problematic Behavior #1:

Question	My Answer
How much time does this take per day?	
What activities does it prevent me from doing?	
How does it affect my relationships?	
What would I be doing if I wasn't doing this?	
Distress level if I DON'T do it (1-10):	

Problematic Behavior #2:

Question	My Answer
How much time does this take per day?	
What activities does it prevent me from doing?	
How does it affect my relationships?	
What would I be doing if I wasn't doing this?	
Distress level if I DON'T do it (1-10):	

Problematic Behavior #3:

Question	My Answer
How much time does this take per day?	
What activities does it prevent me from doing?	
How does it affect my relationships?	
What would I be doing if I wasn't doing this?	
Distress level if I DON'T do it (1-10):	

Section 4: Short-Term vs. Long-Term Goals Explained

Changing deeply ingrained patterns takes time. It helps to break the process into manageable steps. Here is how to think about your goals:

Short-Term Goals (1-4 Weeks)	Long-Term Goals (3-12 Months)
Focus on ONE specific behavior at a time	Focus on overall life freedom and values
Small, measurable changes	Big-picture transformation
Build tolerance for discomfort gradually	Live with uncertainty without rituals
Practice new responses to urges	Reclaim time for meaningful activities
Track progress weekly	Reflect on progress monthly

Key Principles for Goal-Setting:

- Be specific: 'I will reduce hand-washing to 3 times per day' is better than 'I will wash less'
- Focus on BEHAVIOR, not feelings: You cannot control thoughts/feelings, but you CAN control actions
- Expect discomfort: Changing patterns WILL feel uncomfortable at first - this is a sign of progress
- Start where you are: Pick goals that are challenging but not overwhelming (aim for 60-70% difficulty)
- Progress over perfection: A slip-up is NOT a failure - it is information about what to adjust

Section 5: My Short-Term Goals (Next 1-4 Weeks)

Using your top 3 problematic behaviors from Section 3, write ONE short-term goal for each. Your short-term goal should describe a specific, observable change in behavior.

How to write a good short-term goal:

Formula: 'When [trigger/situation happens], instead of [my usual behavior], I will [new response], [frequency/duration].'

Short-Term Goal #1 (for Behavior #1)

Trigger/Situation: _____

My usual response: _____

My NEW response: _____

How often I will practice: _____

How I will know I succeeded: _____

Short-Term Goal #2 (for Behavior #2)

Trigger/Situation: _____

My usual response: _____

My NEW response: _____

How often I will practice: _____

How I will know I succeeded: _____

Short-Term Goal #3 (for Behavior #3)

Trigger/Situation: _____

My usual response: _____

My NEW response: _____

How often I will practice: _____

How I will know I succeeded: _____

Examples of Good Short-Term Goals:

- When I leave the house, instead of checking the lock 5 times, I will check once and walk away, every day this week.
- When I feel the urge to wash my hands after touching a doorknob, I will wait 10 minutes before washing, 3x per day.
- When I have an intrusive thought, instead of mentally reviewing it for 20 minutes, I will acknowledge it and redirect to my current task.
- When I want to ask my partner for reassurance, I will write the question down instead of asking, at least once per day.
- Instead of spending 45 minutes in the shower with rituals, I will limit my shower to 15 minutes, 5 days this week.

Section 6: My Long-Term Goals (Next 3-12 Months)

Long-term goals describe the LIFE you want to be living when these patterns no longer control you. Think about what you would do with the time and energy you currently spend on your problematic behaviors.

Life Areas to Consider:

Life Area	How my patterns currently limit me	What I want instead (Long-Term Goal)
Relationships		
Work / School		
Daily Routines		
Hobbies / Fun		
Independence		
Social Life		

Examples of Good Long-Term Goals:

- In 6 months, I want my morning routine to take 30 minutes (currently 2 hours due to rituals).
- In 6 months, I want to be able to travel without needing to check and recheck everything before leaving.
- In 9 months, I want to make decisions without spending days analyzing every possible outcome.
- In 12 months, I want to touch objects in public without excessive hand-washing afterward.
- In 6 months, I want to trust my own memory when I lock the door, without going back to check.
- In 12 months, I want to have an intrusive thought and let it pass without performing any mental rituals.

Section 7: Building a Bridge - Short-Term to Long-Term

Pick your MOST IMPORTANT long-term goal. Now create a step-by-step plan that builds gradually over time. Each step should be slightly harder than the last.

My Most Important Long-Term Goal:

My Gradual Step-by-Step Plan:

Step	What I Will Do	When	Difficulty	Done?
1		Week 1-2	/10	

2		Week 3-4	/10	
3		Month 2	/10	
4		Month 3	/10	
5		Month 4-6	/10	
6		Month 6-12	/10	

Tip: Rate difficulty on a scale of 1-10. Start with steps rated 3-5, and build up to 7-9. Never start with a 10 - that's a recipe for discouragement. Gradual is the key.

Section 8: What Will Get in the Way

Be honest about the urges, thoughts, and situations that will make it hard to stick to your goals. Planning ahead for obstacles makes it much more likely you will succeed.

The Urge / Pattern	When It's Strongest	My Planned Response
e.g., Urge to check the door	When leaving for work, rushed	Lock once, say 'done,' walk away
e.g., Need to ask for reassurance	After an intrusive thought	Write it down, wait 1 hour

Section 9: Learning to Sit with Discomfort

One of the most important skills you will develop is the ability to tolerate discomfort without acting on the urge. Here is what to expect:

The Discomfort Cycle:

- TRIGGER: Something happens (a thought, a situation, a sensation)
- URGE: You feel a strong pull to perform your behavior/ritual
- PEAK: The discomfort rises - this is the hardest moment (usually lasts 15-45 minutes)
- DECLINE: If you DON'T act on the urge, the discomfort WILL decrease on its own
- FREEDOM: Over time, the urges become weaker and shorter

What to do when the urge hits:

- Acknowledge it: 'I notice I'm having the urge to check/wash/repeat.'
- Accept it: 'This feeling is uncomfortable, but it is not dangerous.'
- Wait: Set a timer for 15 minutes. Most urges peak and begin to decline within this time.
- Redirect: Engage in a meaningful activity (call a friend, take a walk, start a task).
- Record: Note what happened in your tracking sheet below.

Remember: Every time you resist the urge, you are retraining your brain. The discomfort is temporary. The freedom is lasting.

Section 10: Weekly Tracking Sheet

Use this sheet to track your progress each day. For each day, note: Did you face a trigger? Did you resist the urge? How long did the discomfort last? Rate your distress (1-10) at its peak.

Week of: _____

Day	Trigger	Resisted?	Discomfort (min)	Peak (1-10)	Notes
Monday					
Tuesday					
Wednesday					
Thursday					
Friday					
Saturday					
Sunday					

Section 11: Session Check-In & Reflection

Complete this section before each therapy session to help guide your discussion.

This week, I successfully resisted urges _____ times.

My biggest win this week was:

The hardest moment was:

What I learned about my patterns:

What I want to adjust for next week:

My current distress level (1-10): _____

Time spent on problematic behaviors per day (estimate): _____ hours _____ minutes

Compared to when I started, my behaviors are (circle one):

Much Worse / Slightly Worse / Same / Slightly Better / Much Better

Section 12: My Progress Milestones

Check off each milestone as you reach it. Celebrate your progress - every step matters.

- ☐ I identified my top 3 problematic behaviors
- ☐ I resisted an urge for the first time (even for a few minutes)
- ☐ I went an entire day without seeking reassurance
- ☐ I reduced the time spent on rituals by 25%
- ☐ I did something I was avoiding because of my patterns
- ☐ I sat with discomfort for 15+ minutes without acting on the urge
- ☐ I reduced the time spent on rituals by 50%
- ☐ I made a decision without excessive analysis or reassurance
- ☐ I had an intrusive thought and let it pass without a ritual
- ☐ I went a full week with minimal interference from my patterns
- ☐ I accomplished a long-term goal from this worksheet

Final Reminder

You did not choose to have these patterns. But you CAN choose how you respond to them. Every time you resist an urge - even imperfectly - you are building a new path in your brain. Change is not about willpower. It is about practice, patience, and self-compassion. You are doing something incredibly brave by facing this.

Bring this worksheet to every session. Review it with your therapist.